

With the increasing number of Internet users, e-mail services, too, have undergone drastic changes. One of the most apparent changes has been the explosion in storage space. With Google entering the mail arena with its free Web mail service, GMail, most providers are now in the race to provide more and more mail storage space. Though the Internet has innumerable number of mail service providers, Yahoo!, GMail and Hotmail remain the most widely used.

4.1.2 Instant Messengers

A cousin of e-mail, an Instant Messenger (IM) is a client that allows you to send an ‘instant’ text message to anyone on your list of friends. The caveat is that the receiver must be online and using the same service to be able to receive your message. This relay of a message in real-time and the presence awareness feature—what lets you know whether your contact is online—are some of the differentiating features of IMs from e-mail. IMs have evolved from IRC (Internet Relay Chat) to their present form, where you can transfer voice and files as well.

In many ways, the Instant Messenger can be regarded as the predecessor of VoIP (Voice over Internet Protocol)

and video conferencing. MSN Messenger, Yahoo! Messenger and ICQ are some of the most popular IMs today.



Messengers help keep in touch in real-time